Aryan Birth

By Elizabeth Page

DAVID: You can't help who your parents are, right? I mean even if you buy the Hindu thing-that the soul is out there looking to get reborn. Waiting for, say, two child abusers to get pregnant. Not that I'm blaming the kids on the wrong end of a cigarette, I'm not.

And not that I'm blaming her parents. Necessarily. Y'see that's the thing about the Hindu trip-if the soul wants to come back, you're stuck. This is your life. Too bad if you don't like it.

So why blame her, right? She's stuck. "Fraulein Mueller, in ziss lifetime you vill vork on your anger, if you please. And you vill take it out on David Cohen. You'll know him. He's a nice boy viss a bullseye on his heart."

Is there anything worse than whining? Besides, if you pick your parents, you damn sure pick your lover. So we're both to blame.

INTRODUCTION

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DAVID: The first thing I saw was her soul. Scene: I'm in the islands, in a temple, meditating. The sun's coming up-you can hear it, the wind picks up, the trees start to move, the birds sing. I open my eyes ...

She's so deep in the meditation it's like she isn't there. I can't even make out her face. Just this hum-energy. Hummm ... She hummed me in and that was it.

Yeah, she was beautiful. We chose each other. We couldn't help it.

I knew it wasn't going anywhere, I was going home – New York. She was going back to Austria.

I went home. And she came with me.

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The only problem-actually there were two problems. Th. visa and the TV. The visa meant she had to leave the country Soon. Actually I guess it's tied in-borders, nationalism, the World War II thing. I live in this country, she lives in that country. And in this country we hate that country. Which is where the TV comes in. We were in the apartment a lot so the TV was on. "Nazis und communists. Nazis und communists. Das ist all you people know."

You make the bad guy a Nazi, you don't even have to give him a character, just put him in a uniform. Or her.

Where we got into trouble was when I'd try to defend the programming-which meant, of course, defending the obsession in this country with Nazis. Because I'd have to get into, y'know, what they did. And then she'd get all defensive and think I was attacking her family. And I'd get all defensive and say that her family would have gassed my family.

I don't know what I expected. I guess, well, remorse. Not that she did anything but y'know, sort of collective remorse. I mean I could understand why she was defensive. If my father were a Nazi ...

When I saw her meditating I didn't pick up that her father was a Nazi. It didn't occur to me, all right? They were all Nazis. It was a political party. People were starving, there weren't any jobs, it was politics. They lived in the mountains, her father'd never even seen a Jew.

So fine, I wasn't shtupping her father. He used to beat her.

And lock her in a closet. Now this was interesting. She didn't think there was anything particularly wrong with that. Not that she enjoyed it, she hated him. But that's how kids were brought up there. If they misbehaved, they were hit. Or locked up.

Do you read the Times? The New York Times? Did you see that article on the op-ed page, This psychiatrist gets this hunch-he's been travelling

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around Europe, noticing how kids in different countries are different, play differently, and he gets this hunch. This is in the early 70s

[He takes a newspaper article out of his pocket.]

I carry this around. It makes me feel like less of a jerk. Okay ... "The result was that the Danish and Italian adults committed no acts of aggression against children as compared with 73 aggressive acts by German adults against children. The German children committed 258 acts of aggression against other children, as compared with 48 aggressive acts by Italian children and 20 by Danish children. The tentative moral of the story is that Germans mistreat their children more often than Danish or Italian adults, and that the children take it out on other children. One would suppose that aggressive children grow up into aggressive adults - adults whom I don't trust ... "

It goes on. Anyway. Now obviously the point is not that the Fascists had troubled childhoods and we should like overturn Nuremburg. But he used to beat her up. And that does something to a person. I mean you can understand how they might not be as sensitive maybe as they could be. People like that need a lot of love.

So I've got this wounded bird. And she doesn't even know she's wounded. She thinks she's this invincible Rhine maiden Brunhilde, running around the world, having an affair with a Jewish man. She doesn't even realize she should be terrified.

Okay so she decides she wants to go to this peace conference being held at another ashram up in Canada. A lot of people she knows are gonna be there. This is, what, '87, before the wall came down and I'm thinking, okay, maybe we can break through some of the denial going on here. An international peace conference has to deal with Fascism. Doesn't it?

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So we go.

You ever been on the Freedom Trail? You follow the yellow brick road around Boston from one old thing to another? Anyway we're driving and we hit Boston-and she's heard of it-so I take her on the Freedom Trail. "Images of the Holocaust." Don't ask. There it was, these floor to ceiling blow-ups of emaciatedskeletal-children, mounds of corpses. You've seen 'em. She's very quiet. I ask her if she wants to leave-she's always dismissed this stuff before-but she says no and so we walk through the exhibit. It was pretty good. I've seen more gruesome stuff-y'know the documentation of some of the medical-and I use the term loosely-experiments. Where they filled women's wombs with cement, froze people alive. In the name of science. But they had a jar full of hair, piles of baby shoes, memos describing transport and "disinfection" and of course the photographs.

One of our main arguments was about the nature of the camps.

Really of the "final solution" itself. She claimed it was wartime and that the camps were prisoner of war camps. I know, but I'm telling you, she actually believed that. I found that out in Boston. Until that day she'd say, okay, there were maybe individual sadists who got carried away, that the Japanese had camps, that the Brazilians slaughter their Indians. I kept screaming about the decision coming from the top, that it was planned, that it started in someone's heart and mind, that it wasn't just separate, impulsive acts of sadism, that the act of deciding to annihilate a people-that's what made it such an abomination.

More patriotic ... and more Jewish.

We leave the exhibit. She says, "They don't teach this in the schools. Our parents don't talk about it. It is taboo. Verboten." She's quiet the rest of the day.

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I changed her. Whatever you can say about what happened, she was changed. Okay so we get to this peace conference. I don't know what I expected. I guess ... "Us and Them." Y'know, what you get when you take the bus to Washington to do a march. Placards, cameras, people with hangers on their heads screaming at people with pictures of butchered fetuses. A "we shall overcome" kinda thing.

Well this was all "Us". I mean it makes sense that none of "Them" are gonna pack a sleeping bag and catch a cab to the mountains so "Us" could have a target. But it was weird. It was like whatta you do when the enemy isn't there.

There was an article in Vanity Fair awhile back about how the children of the Nazi superstars are getting together for group therapy. This blew my mind-having been through every kind of therapy, self-help, analysis, primal scream, tonka bats-you name it. I'd practically written the article in my head before I paged back to where it started-middle-aged Nazi kinder holding hands and sobbing. Let me just read you this one little bit.

[He takes the article out of his pocket.]

This is Martin Borman, Jr., about age 14, who's been taken for tea with his little sister at Frau Pothast's-Himmler's mistress. Okay, they've had chocolates, a little turn around the garden, now it's time for a special treat. She takes the kids up to the attic.

"When she opened the door and we flocked in, we didn't understand at first what the objects in that room were-until she explained, quite scientifically, you know. Tables, and chairs, made of parts of human bodies. There was a chair ... The seat was a human pelvis, the legs human legs-on human feet. And then she picked up one of a stack of copies of Mein Kampf-all I could think of was that my father had told me not to bother to read it, as it had been

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outdated by events. She showed us the cover, made of human skin, and explained that the Dachau prisoners who produced it used the Ruckenhaut-the skin of the back-to make it."

[DAVID *takes several long breaths and then looks around the audience for a moment.]*

Be glad it hurts. That's the point. It should hurt. It must hurt. Borman, Jr.-who after all was showing up for therapy, I mean, he's at least acknowledging there's a problem-Borman Jr.'s described as relating this incident with a "toneless voice." He later says that to call the people who did this swine is an insult to swine but other than getting red in the face, that's it.

Am I the only crier here? No. Something's missing-maybe it was never there or maybe they bred it out of them but that inclination to pity, compassion, emotional identification, tears ...

Anyway, I'm having a wonderful time in the mountains ... enjoying simultaneous translations of scintillating speeches by obscure Nato attaches, taking Kirlian photographs of my chakras and learning how to manipulate my aura so as to create a peaceful personality, grading an airstrip behind the tents and meditating nightly so as to attract peaceful extraterrestrials, learning everyone's rising sign, eating soggy samosas, smiling and chanting in the rain. Let me tell you, peace is hard work.

And Maria? She might as well be in Berlin. She won't connect. And I'm not making her. Hey, I've read as many self help books as the next American. If the fraulein needs her space, fine. I know Boston wigged her out. I saw something and she's scrambling for cover. So let her scramble, we're going home.

We took a train back from Montreal. She wasn't feeling well and slept

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against me for an hour. You remember the dumbest things, y'know. The way that felt, the weight of her head against my shoulder. Like a baby's head, heavy.

We get back to New York and I don't know. Maybe it was being around a lot of people at the ashram but suddenly the silence in the apartment was sonic. I mean I could hear her breathing. And since she wasn't doing much talking, I started reading her breaths. A short one-she just thought of something. She's holding her breath-she knows I'm listening. A long one-how long till I get out of here.

Fine. I go see my sister for a couple of days. She wants space, I'll give her some space. Sixteen hours and she wants me to come back. Anyway I go home-she's still not feeling good. She's pregnant.

Oh and she's Austrian and the clock's ticking, she's got, what, a couple weeks and her visa runs out which means if I even want to talk to her without paying Ma Bell we have to get married. So.

Jews don't have reincarnation. Not that they don't take the long view but you only get one chance with them. Hindus get all the second chances they want only they don't enjoy them. Basically Vishnu says okay, you want it, you got it-the punchline being that someday you'll realize you don't need it and then you get the door prize-bliss divine. But until then, you're coming back. Which puts a certain spin on parenthood. I mean your kid isn't new-he's coming back. Which makes it less intimidating-you're just one in a long line of fathers-and more intimidating-why me?

What does this kid need? What are we going to teach each other? I was really curious. I was ready.

She wasn't. She hadn't found herself yet. Couldn't I understand that she needed to do that? Didn't I realize ...

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I'm not a right-to-lifer, okay? I mean I let it happen. But that doesn't mean I have to be happy about it. This wasn't just a tablespoon of cells to me, okay? This was her, this was our relationship, this was me, my son, my daughter, my genes, my history.

[He taks a deep breath. He's rattled. He starts searching in his pockets ...] They kept correspondence ...

[He finds a Xerox, spreads it out. Touching it seems to steady him. He reads ...]

"To the Central Construction Office of the SS and Police, Auschwitz.

Subject: Crematoria Two and Three for the camp.

We acknowledge receipt of your order for five triple furnaces, including two electric elevators for raising the corpses and one emergency elevator ... "

It's that cleaning up thing, y'know? *[Singing.]* "The party's over ... " You think I'm sick? They were competing for these gigs. *[He searches his pockets ...]* And the competition suggested ... *[He finds another Xerox]* ... what...

"For putting the bodies into the furnaces, we suggest simply a metal fork moving on cylinders. For transporting the corpses ... "

[He trails off. He's rattled and takes a deep breath, speaks quite calmly ...]

Look, I'm glad I live where it's legal. But you have to admit it's not like filling a tooth or getting a mole cut off. I mean if you choose to "not continue" a life for the sake of your own life, you pay the price. Life is expensive.

But Maria, she was impervious. She'd made the decision and that was it. Who cares. At first I thought she was just reacting to me, y'know because I was really upset. So, y'know, she'd be cool. But no. It wasn't that. And it wasn't just that she was selfish although I think she is. It really honestly didn't mean anything to her. And I don't mean me or the relationship. She claimed she still cared about me, wanted the relationship. But the baby-it might as well have been a hangnail.

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And that scared me. She called it "the procedure"-I thought she didn't like the word abortion but to her that's what it was. A "procedure". *[In a German accent.]* "For putting ze bodies into ze furnace, ve suggest simply a metal fork moving on cylinders."

As soon as she made her decision she started drinking again-I mean she's not an alcoholic but y'know pregnant women aren't supposed to drink. And she started having wine with dinner again. And I thought of that poor kid being drowned in Beaujolais. Even if it was gonna die in a couple of days. She said I was sentimental. And I called her a fascist bitch. And that was the end of that.

Ever since the wall came down, the Berlin Wall, I've been having a dream. I hear knocking at the window and I turn to see what it is-a branch maybe. But it's a little child, a little girl, hanging out there in the darkness, knocking on the window, wanting to come in.

I know what I'm about to say is not spiritual. But I feel like I was allowed to experience something. She was cold. Maybe I'm sentimental but she was ruthless. Without Ruth. Who, if you remember the story, was a very compassionate woman. Maria had no compassion and I don't think any of them do. That was always my trouble thinking about the holocaust. I could never imagine how a human being could do that to another human being. But now I can. And maybe that makes me a racist and just as bad as they are but I don't trust them. And I never will.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Elizabeth Page
Book: The Best American Short Plays 1992-1993
ISBN: 978-1557831675
Publisher: Hal Leonard Corporation
Date (Month/Year): Nov 1993

AWARD HISTORY

MN State Qualifier